

Daily Economic Briefing

Wednesday 23 September 2026 | Window: Mon 21 Sept 20:00 ET – Tue 22 Sept 20:21 ET (Tue 22 Sept session) | Research cutoff 22 Sept 20:21 ET | Edition 26

Assumptions, corrections and status this edition

- Correction — Block/Hess open thread closed, premise was wrong:** edition 25 carried an open thread asking for primary-source confirmation that Block Inc. would replace Hess Corp. in the S&P 500 "effective Wed 23 Sept." This was a stale premise: Block already replaced Hess in the index before the open on **23 July 2025**, following Chevron's completed Hess acquisition — over a year before this window.^[34] No S&P 500 constituent change was found effective this window beyond the already-reported 21 Sept quarterly rebalance.^[35]
- Fed Chair Kevin Warsh and the next FOMC date (27–28 Oct 2026) both re-verified fresh** against federalreserve.gov today, per standing practice.^{[19][20]}
- Official Treasury H.15 par yields fetched directly and cleanly for a second straight edition.^[21]
- Kalshi's October-hike contract failed direct fetch (HTTP 429) a fourth straight edition;** this run's search-cached figure was internally inconsistent (mismatched Yes/No framing) and is not used — see Annex A.
- Gold has a genuine, unreconciled same-day split:** Kitco's 4:32pm ET read and USAGOLD's own report disagree by more than a dollar-for-dollar rounding difference; both are reported below rather than picking one silently.^{[40][41]}
- Worthington Enterprises (WOR) shows a large gap between intraday earnings-reaction coverage (approx. +15% to \$67.94) and its logged close (+1.36% to \$58.94) — not reconciled; see Annex A.

60-second read

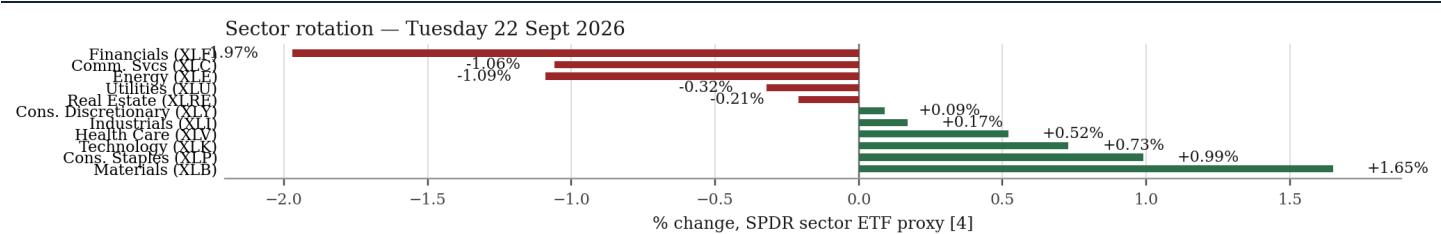
- A financials-led rotation split the tape: the Dow fell 0.36% and Financials (XLF -1.97%) was the day's worst sector — JPMorgan -3.42%, Wells Fargo -3.92% — while the Nasdaq Composite set a second straight record close (+0.45%) and Materials (XLB +1.65%) led; the S&P 500 finished effectively flat.
- Viking Therapeutics (VCTX) was the session's standout mover, +35.67% to \$40.85, on positive VK2735 maintenance-dosing obesity-drug data; Eli Lilly and Novo Nordisk both dipped in sympathy.
- VIX closed 14.21, its lowest close of the year and down 4.44% on the day — the vol complex fell across the board (VVIX, VIX9D) with no stress signal, even as equity leadership rotated hard underneath the surface.
- Oil fell for a second straight session (Brent -1.09% to \$99.25, WTI -1.24% to \$94.59) as Saudi Arabia restarted its East-West Pipeline toward reopening Yanbu exports and US and Iranian officials held a roughly three-hour UN General Assembly sideline meeting that President Trump called "a very good meeting."
- October-hike odds stayed a genuinely wide multi-venue range (Polymarket approx. 53% hike; Kalshi unreadable a fourth straight edition; CME FedWatch citations split approx. 56% vs. approx. 59.7%) heading into a heavy week: Norges Bank, Riksbank and Banxico all decide Thursday, the Trump-Xi Washington summit culminates Thursday, and the SNB looks likely to follow Friday.

1. Market recap

S&P 500 7,764.64 -0.06 (-0.00%)	Dow 51,863.69 -185.14 (-0.36%)	Nasdaq Comp. 27,244.28 +122.19 (+0.45%)	Russell 2000 2,889.92 +14.56 (+0.51%)	VIX 14.21 -4.44%	10-Yr yield 4.96% flat
DXY 100.57 +0.14%			Brent \$99.25 -1.09%		

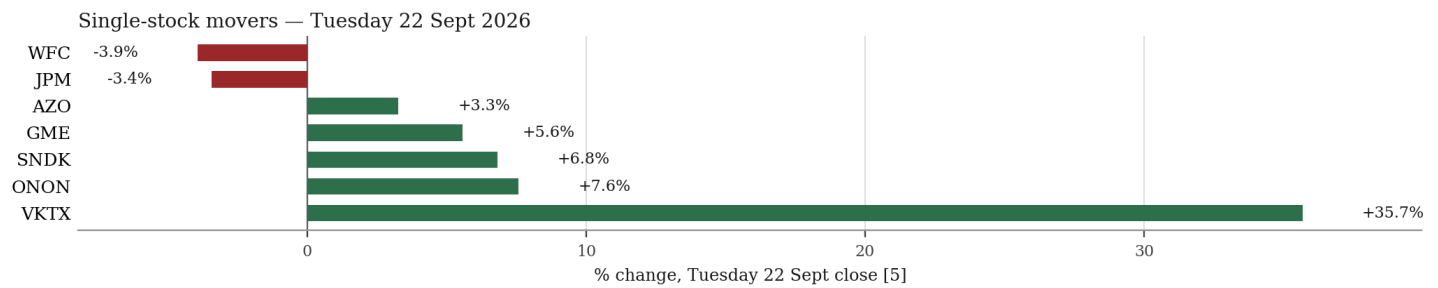
Tuesday 22 September was a rotation day more than a direction day: the S&P 500 closed essentially unchanged at 7,764.64 and the Dow fell 0.36% to 51,863.69, dragged by a sharp financials selloff, while the Nasdaq Composite notched a second consecutive record close at 27,244.28 (+0.45%) and the Russell 2000 outperformed at +0.51%.^{[1][2]} Corroborating market wraps and ETF-proxy checks (SPY -0.02%, DIA -0.34%, QQQ +0.81%, IWM +0.57%) confirmed direction and magnitude.^{[3][4]} Underneath the flat headline index, Financials (XLF -1.97%) was the worst sector and Materials (XLB +1.65%) the best — a clean reversal of Monday's Communication-Services/Technology-led, Energy-lagging leadership.^[4]

2. Equities and earnings



Bank stocks led the Dow's decline — JPMorgan -3.42% to \$340.00, Wells Fargo -3.92% to \$83.15, Morgan Stanley -2.88% to \$200.18 — consistent with XLF's sector-wide -1.97%.^[5] Multiple wraps tied the move to a Bloomberg report ("Meta's Muse Drags Down Stocks That Depend on Consumer Inertia") arguing that Meta's new "Muse" AI shopping agent threatens commission-dependent business models; only the headline and snippet were accessible (the piece is paywalled), so this read-through is reported as plausible context rather than a confirmed driver.^[6] Richmond Fed President Tom Barkin's Tuesday remarks flagging continued openness to further rate hikes are a more concretely-sourced contributing factor for bank-stock weakness (see Section 3).^[29] Online travel agencies traded on the same Muse-disintermediation theme: Expedia and Booking Holdings both traded weak, Expedia's overhang compounded by Morgan Stanley's 16 Sept downgrade to Underweight (\$235 PT) and Booking's by the EU General Court's 9 Sept ruling upholding the block on its approx. \$1.9bn ETraveli acquisition; Expedia partly offset its own weakness by announcing a Muse integration deal same-day.^{[7][8]} Elsewhere in travel, falling fuel costs lifted Carnival (approx. +4%) and American Airlines (approx. +2.2%).^[9]

Single-stock movers



Ticker	Move	Driver
Viking Therapeutics (VKTX)	+35.67%	Positive VK2735 maintenance-dosing obesity-drug data (22% placebo-adjusted weight loss at week 33); Lilly and Novo Nordisk both dipped in sympathy ^[14]
On Holding (ONON)	+7.58%	Investor Day: first-ever buyback (approx. \$1bn through 2029) and new long-term targets (CHF 5.6bn revenue by 2029); Nike ticked up in read-across ^[15]
SanDisk (SNDK)	+6.82%	Rosenblatt Securities initiated at Buy, \$2,400 PT, on NAND flash's role in AI infrastructure ^[17]
GameStop (GME)	+5.58%	Continued reaction to CEO Ryan Cohen's disclosed Monday purchase of 1.15m additional shares (approx. \$26.4m) ^[18]
AutoZone (AZO)	+3.26%	FQ4 EPS \$56.05 vs. \$54.08 est. (beat); revenue \$6.59bn vs. \$6.69bn est. (miss); same-store sales +1.5%
JPMorgan Chase (JPM)	-3.42%	Led the financials-sector selloff (see above)
Wells Fargo (WFC)	-3.92%	Same financials-sector selloff

Other earnings since Monday's cutoff: MillerKnoll's FQ1 adjusted EPS of \$0.53 beat estimates (approx. \$0.35) on revenue of \$923.4m that missed (approx. \$942.7m); it guided FQ2 EPS to \$0.43–\$0.49.^[13] Worthington Enterprises beat FQ1 estimates (adjusted EPS \$0.82 vs. \$0.75 est.; revenue \$343.9m vs. \$331.3m est., +13% YoY) and spiked intraday to approx. \$67.94 (approx. +15%) on the print, but closed the session up a comparatively modest 1.36% at \$58.94 — the two figures are not reconciled (Annex A).^[11] KB Home reported after Tuesday's close: non-GAAP EPS \$1.05 beat \$0.90 est., revenue was in line, but full-year sales guidance softened and shares rose approx. 2.9% in after-hours trading.^[12] PayPal, which announced a Meta Muse checkout integration alongside Stripe and Shopify, closed up a modest +0.51% to \$52.89 despite larger intraday swings reported by some aggregators — the stockanalysis.com closing print is used here as authoritative.^[16] Meta itself closed -0.63% to \$736.60, digesting Monday's approx. +11% Muse-driven surge, before ticking up to \$741 (+0.60%) after-hours.^[5]

3. Macro, policy and rates

Fed Chair Kevin Warsh and the next FOMC meeting (27–28 October 2026) were both re-confirmed fresh against federalreserve.gov's own pages today.^{[19][20]} Official Treasury H.15 par yields posted cleanly again: the 10-year held at 4.96% and the 2-year eased to 4.43% from Monday's 4.45%.^[21] Monday's SOFR print, published Tuesday with the standard one-day lag, was 3.85% — unchanged from the elevated level first seen 17 September; Tuesday's own SOFR reading will not post until Wednesday and the precise mechanism behind the 17 Sept jump from 3.62% is still not officially confirmed beyond the plausible read-through of the FOMC's 25bp hike (Annex A).^[22] October-hike odds remain a genuinely wide range: Polymarket's own market showed approx. 53% hike / 46% hold on a clean direct fetch (approx. \$10.27m in volume);^[23] Kalshi's direct fetch failed with HTTP 429 for a fourth straight edition and this run's search-cached figure was internally inconsistent, so it is not used;^[24] secondary citations for CME FedWatch continue to disagree with each other (approx. 56% vs. approx. 59.7%), not just with the other venues.^[25] Richmond Fed President Tom Barkin said Tuesday that inflation pressures "may take time to pass" and that September's hike will help slow inflation only gradually — a hawkish-leaning signal that coincided with the bank-stock selloff.^[29] The Richmond Fed's regional Manufacturing Index fell to -2 in September from +4 in August, missing a +5 consensus, with new orders and shipments both swinging negative.^[27] The Philadelphia Fed's Nonmanufacturing Business Outlook for September also released Tuesday, but secondary aggregators reported materially conflicting headline figures with no clean primary confirmation obtained by cutoff (Annex A).^[28] No BLS or Census releases were scheduled for Tuesday 22 September, per each agency's own release calendar.^[26]

A busy central-bank week lies immediately ahead: Norges Bank's own decision-calendar page confirms Thursday 24 September for its rate decision and Monetary Policy Report;^[30] Sweden's Riksbank is reported, via secondary coverage, to also decide and publish its Monetary Policy Report Thursday 24 September (riksbank.se's own pages did not render body text confirming this directly);^[31] Mexico's Banxico is likewise reported for Thursday 24 September via secondary coverage.^[32] The Swiss National Bank's exact date, an open thread since edition 25, now looks best-supported as Friday 25 September — a Reuters economist poll and two other secondary sources converge on that date, and a genuine SNB page titled "Monetary policy assessment of 25 September 2025" supports the edition-25 hypothesis that an earlier "24th" citation was a mis-surfaced prior-year article — but SNB's own site has not yet posted a September 2026 assessment page to confirm directly.^[33] Separately, Xi Jinping's Washington state visit runs 23–25 September, with the Trump-Xi meeting, a Rose Garden ceremony and a State Dinner all set for Thursday 24 September;^[54] and the US import ban on Canadian dairy, alcohol and motor vehicles remains on track to take effect Tuesday 29 September, with no reported change this window.^[55]

4. Commodities and FX

Instrument	Level	Chg	Note
Brent crude	\$99.25	-1.09%	Saudi pipeline restart + US-Iran UNGA talks
WTI crude (Oct contract)	\$94.59	-1.24%	Same drivers; reconciles cleanly vs. Monday's \$95.78
Gold (spot)	\$4,358.80	-0.45%	Kitco/Fortune 4:32pm ET; USAGOLD read materially lower (Annex disclosure)

Gold (COMEX Dec futures)	\$4,401.59	+0.40%	Genuine spot/futures divergence, not an error
Silver (spot)	\$65.27	−0.84%	Gold-silver ratio widened to approx. 66.0
Copper (LME cash, via Westmetall)	\$14,797/t	+0.06%	lme.com and metal.com both skipped (durable multi-edition failures)
DXY	100.57	+0.14%	
EUR/USD	1.1465	−0.13%	Cross-corroborated vs. NordFX (1.1475)
GBP/USD	1.3371	−0.13%	Sterling near lowest since late July; cross-corroborated
USD/JPY	157.369	+0.21%	Continued post-BoJ yen weakness

Oil fell for a second straight session on two converging catalysts: Saudi Arabia restarted its East-West Pipeline (shut since the approx. 13 Sept drone strikes) and moved toward resuming crude loadings at the Red Sea port of Yanbu, targeting full pipeline-capacity restoration within about six weeks;^[39] separately, US and Iranian officials held a roughly three-hour meeting on the UN General Assembly sidelines that President Trump called "a very good meeting."^[36] Brent and WTI both triangulated cleanly across three independent sources.^{[36][37]} A UAE state-wire recap also resolved edition 25's flagged WTI ambiguity: Monday's front-month October contract settled at \$95.78 (not the lower \$92.28–95.80 range previously reported), while the separate November contract settled at \$92.47 — the earlier split was a front-month-vs-second-month mismatch, not a data error.^[38] Gold's spot read carries a genuine, unresolved same-day divergence: Kitco's 4:32pm ET print showed \$4,358.80 (−0.45%), while USAGOLD's own report showed a materially lower \$4,307.63, which recomputed against Monday's logged \$4,378.63 baseline would be approx. −1.62%; the two could not be reconciled to a common timestamp.^{[40][41]} COMEX December gold futures actually rose 0.40% the same session — a genuine spot/futures divergence, not an error.^[42] Copper's Westmetall-sourced fallback chain (lme.com and Shanghai Metals Market both skipped after four and four straight failures respectively) showed a near-flat session after Monday's sharp +1.78% move.^[44] EUR/USD and GBP/USD both now carry a second independent corroborating source beyond Yahoo Finance for the first time, resolving edition 25's single-sourced flag.^{[45][46][47]}

5. Derivatives, volatility and positioning

VIX closed 14.21, down 4.44% from Monday's 14.87 (computed manually against the last logged close, per standing practice) and its lowest close of the year — corroborated by a CNBC live-blog quote citing the same level.^{[49][50]} The Cboe delayed-quotes feed returned a clean sweep this edition, with every series (VIX, VIX9D, VIX3M, VIX6M, VVIX, SKEW) carrying a genuinely fresh 22 September *last_trade_time*.^[49] Term structure stayed in normal contango (VIX9D 12.13, VIX3M 17.61, VIX6M 19.79), with no re-emergence of the post-FOMC VIX9D distortion tracked across editions 23–24.^[49] VVIX fell in sympathy with spot vol to 83.17 (−3.03%), while SKEW ticked up modestly to 144.80 (+1.84%) — a small richening in tail-risk pricing even as realized and implied vol both fell.^[49] Tuesday's VIX options volume is not reported: Cboe's stats page returned a figure identical, to the contract, to Monday's already-logged print, indicating a stale or cached read rather than fresh data (Annex A). CFTC's Commitments of Traders report remains dated 15 September (published 18 September), confirmed directly against cftc.gov with no new report posted this window; the next update is due approximately Friday 25 September.^[52] Dealer gamma remains unavailable: SpotGamma's page returned only boilerplate text with no extractable live figure, and no other credible contemporaneous estimate was found (Annex A). On funding, Monday's SOFR print (published Tuesday, standard T+1 lag) held at 3.85% with no repo-stress headlines identified for Tuesday's session.^[22]

6. The day ahead

Date	Event	Consensus / context
Wed 23 Sept	S&P Global flash Manufacturing & Services PMIs, 9:45am ET	August flash manufacturing was 53.2; no clean September consensus figure obtained (Annex A)
Thu 24 Sept	Initial jobless claims; New home sales (Aug); Norges Bank, Riksbank, Banxico decisions; Trump-Xi summit culminates	Central-bank cluster plus a state-visit centerpiece in one session
Fri 25 Sept	Durable goods orders, Aug advance; SNB decision (best-supported date, unconfirmed by SNB directly); next CFTC CoT report due	SNB: Reuters poll had 40 of 41 economists expecting a hold at 0.00%
Tue 29 Sept	Conference Board Consumer Confidence; US import ban on Canadian dairy/alcohol/motor vehicles takes effect	No reported change to the ban's scope or timing this window

Sector setup we take into Wednesday's session

- Financials enter Wednesday on the week's weakest sector print (XLF −1.97%) with a hawkish Fed cross-current (Barkin) and an unverified but widely-cited AI-disintermediation overhang — watch for follow-through or a dead-cat bounce in JPM/WFC/MS.
- Materials (XLB +1.65%) and Consumer Staples (XLP +0.99%) led Tuesday with no single dominant catalyst identified; Technology (XLK +0.73%) extended its multi-session strength even as the Nasdaq's record close was driven more by breadth than by the single-name chip story that dominated Monday.
- Energy (XLE −1.09%) enters Wednesday with oil still under pressure from the Saudi pipeline restart and US-Iran diplomacy; a durable Hormuz/Red Sea de-escalation would be a fresh headwind for the sector into month-end.
- A five-central-bank cluster (Norges Bank, Riksbank, Banxico Thursday; SNB likely Friday) plus the Trump-Xi summit's Thursday culmination make the back half of the week the more binary macro risk, not Wednesday's PMI prints.

Annex A — Data points sought but not verified this edition

- Tuesday 22 Sept's own SOFR reading — standard T+1 lag, will publish Wednesday 23 Sept.
- Exact mechanism behind the 17 Sept SOFR jump (3.62% → 3.85%) — plausibly the FOMC's 25bp hike taking effect, but no NY Fed statement explicitly confirms this.
- Kalshi's October-hike odds — direct fetch rate-limited (HTTP 429) a fourth straight edition; this run's search-cached figure was internally inconsistent and not used.
- CME FedWatch's precise October-hike probability — secondary citations still disagree (approx. 56% vs. approx. 59.7%); no clean single figure obtainable, page itself blocks direct fetch.
- Philadelphia Fed Nonmanufacturing Business Outlook headline for September — conflicting figures across secondary aggregators; no clean philadelphiafed.org confirmation obtained by cutoff.
- September flash PMI consensus estimate for Wednesday's release — not found via quick search.
- Tuesday's VIX options volume — Cboe's stats page returned a figure identical to Monday's already-logged print, indicating a stale/cached read rather than fresh data.
- Dealer gamma / gamma-flip level — SpotGamma's page returned only boilerplate; no other credible contemporaneous third-party figure found.
- SNB's exact September decision date — best-supported as Friday 25 Sept across independent secondary sources, but SNB's own site has not yet posted a confirming release.
- Worthington Enterprises' intraday spike to approx. \$67.94 (approx. +15%) vs. its logged close of \$58.94 (+1.36%) — not reconciled to a single consistent print.
- Full text of Bloomberg's report tying Tuesday's bank/travel selloff to Meta's "Muse" disintermediation thesis — only the headline and snippet were accessible (paywalled).
- Whether Monday's quarterly S&P/Nasdaq-100 index rebalance produced above-normal trading volume or volatility — carried open from edition 25, still unconfirmed either way.

Annex B — Sources

- [1] Yahoo Finance historical index data (^GSPC/^DJI/^IXIC/^RUT), 22 Sept 2026 4:00pm ET close
- [2] FRED, S&P 500 (SP500) series, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis
- [3] Stockanalysis.com, SPY/DIA/QQQ/IWM ETF price history, 22 Sept 2026
- [4] Stockanalysis.com, SPDR sector ETF price history (XLB/XLP/XLK/XLV/XLI/XLY/XLRE/XLU/XLE/XLC/XLF), 22 Sept 2026 close
- [5] Stockanalysis.com, single-stock price history (JPM, WFC, MS, META), 22 Sept 2026 close
- [6] Bloomberg, "Meta's Muse Drags Down Stocks That Depend on Consumer Inertia" (headline/snippet only, paywalled), 22 Sept 2026
- [7] Morgan Stanley research note via Investing.com, Expedia downgrade to Underweight, \$235 PT, 16 Sept 2026
- [8] EU General Court ruling coverage, Booking Holdings/ETravel acquisition block, 9 Sept 2026
- [9] Investing.com/Yahoo Finance market wrap, Carnival/American Airlines fuel-cost rally, 22 Sept 2026
- [11] Investing.com/SEC 8-K, Worthington Enterprises FQ1 earnings, 22 Sept 2026
- [12] SEC 8-K, ChartMill, 24/7 Wall St, KB Home FQ3 earnings, 22 Sept 2026 after-hours
- [13] WTOP (AP)/Investing.com/SEC 8-K, MillerKnoll FQ1 earnings, 22 Sept 2026
- [14] Bloomberg/TipRanks/24/7 Wall St, Viking Therapeutics VK2735 maintenance-dosing data, 22 Sept 2026
- [15] 24/7 Wall St/Benzinga/Finimize, On Holding Investor Day buyback announcement, 22 Sept 2026
- [16] Stockanalysis.com, PayPal (PYPL) price history, 22 Sept 2026 close; Benzinga/Newsquawk, Meta Muse checkout integration coverage
- [17] Investing.com/Benzinga, Rosenblatt Securities SanDisk initiation, 22 Sept 2026
- [18] Bloomberg/Benzinga, GameStop/Ryan Cohen share purchase disclosure, 21 Sept 2026
- [19] Federalreserve.gov, Board of Governors biographies page, fetched 23 Sept 2026
- [20] Federalreserve.gov, FOMC meeting calendar, fetched 23 Sept 2026
- [21] Home.treasury.gov, Daily Treasury Par Yield Curve Rates (H.15), 21 Sept 2026
- [22] New York Fed reference rates (SOFR) via riskfreerates.com, 21 Sept 2026 rate published 22 Sept 2026
- [23] Polymarket, "Fed Decision in October?" market, direct fetch 22–23 Sept 2026
- [24] Kalshi October Fed-decision market — direct fetch failed (HTTP 429); search-cached figure not used
- [25] Secondary aggregator citations of CME FedWatch implied October-hike probability
- [26] BLS.gov and Census.gov release schedules, checked 23 Sept 2026
- [27] Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond, Manufacturing Survey, September 2026
- [28] Secondary aggregator coverage, Philadelphia Fed Nonmanufacturing Business Outlook Survey, September 2026 (conflicting)
- [29] Bloomberg, remarks by Richmond Fed President Thomas Barkin, 22 Sept 2026
- [30] Norges-bank.no, policy-rate-decision calendar page (26-09-24)
- [31] Secondary coverage (riksbank.se calendar structure), Riksbank September 2026 decision date
- [32] Mexicobusiness.news/riotimesonline.com, Banxico September 2026 decision date
- [33] Reuters economist poll (via Yahoo Finance)/ING THINK/Morningstar Europe/snb.ch, SNB September 2026 decision date
- [34] S&P Global press release archive (press.spglobal.com), Block Inc.–Hess Corp. S&P 500 replacement, 18 July 2025
- [35] S&P Dow Jones Indices press release, September 2026 quarterly rebalance, 4 Sept 2026
- [36] Reuters via CNBC, Brent/WTI crude settlement and US-Iran UNGA meeting coverage, 22 Sept 2026
- [37] Investing.com, Brent/WTI historical price data, 22 Sept 2026
- [38] WAM (Emirates News Agency), WTI October/November contract settlement clarification, 21 Sept 2026
- [39] US News/Reuters/Rigzone/The National, Saudi Arabia East-West Pipeline restart and Yanbu resumption, 22 Sept 2026
- [40] Kitco spot gold quote via Fortune, 22 Sept 2026, 4:32pm ET
- [41] USAGOLD, Daily Market Report, 22 Sept 2026
- [42] Investing.com, COMEX gold futures (Dec contract) settlement, 22 Sept 2026
- [44] Westmetall.com, LME copper cash settlement, 18–22 Sept 2026
- [45] Yahoo Finance, DXY/EUR-USD/GBP-USD/USD-JPY historical closes, 22 Sept 2026
- [46] FXStreet/NordFX Market Pulse, DXY and EUR/USD corroboration, 22 Sept 2026
- [47] Secondary market-news aggregate, GBP/USD corroboration, 22 Sept 2026
- [49] Cdn.cboe.com delayed-quotes feed, VIX/VIX9D/VIX3M/VIX6M/VVIX/SKEW, last_trade_time 22 Sept 2026
- [50] CNBC live market blog, VIX close quote (Brett Ewing, First Franklin Financial), 22 Sept 2026
- [52] CFTC.gov, Commitments of Traders report (deachoesf.htm), data as of 15 Sept 2026, published 18 Sept 2026
- [54] Wikipedia/CSIS/The Diplomat, Trump-Xi Washington state-visit schedule, Sept 2026
- [55] CNBC/U.S. News, US import ban on Canadian dairy/alcohol/motor vehicles, effective 29 Sept 2026

Method: every figure traces to a named source in Annex B; where sources disagreed, the better-corroborated figure was used and the conflict disclosed. Nothing estimated or filled from memory — unverifiable items are listed in Annex A. Not investment advice.